

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- A quieter 24-48 hours nationally. The standout story: DfE's first 'Growing Up in the 2020s' survey, published yesterday, finds most Year 8 pupils positive about school and home life, but pupils receiving SEN support are notably less likely to feel they belong at school than their peers (54% v 66%).
- Locally: High Storrs School in Sheffield wrote to families on Wednesday after police received reports of a man approaching young people near Chelsea Park/Nether Edge on recent evenings.

→ **For your school:** *Worth cascading the same personal-safety reminder if any of your pupils travel through that part of the city.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

7 Oct 2026 — Barnsley Council cabinet meets to approve the revised £7.37m budget for the Worsbrough Bridge specialist SEND primary school.

8 Oct 2026 — DfE pupil premium quarter 2 payments for 2026/27 made to academies.

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

NATIONAL: A BELONGING GAP FOR PUPILS WITH SEN SUPPORT

- **First wave of DfE's 'Growing Up in the 2020s' study published.** The new nationally representative study of almost 8,000 Year 8 pupils - commissioned by DfE and run by Anna Freud, UCL and Ipsos - finds strong overall wellbeing (94% satisfied with life; 95-98% positive about friends and family), though a quarter show symptoms of mental ill-health. On school belonging, 63% overall agreed they felt they belonged, falling to 54% among pupils receiving SEN support (v 66% of peers) and 57% among girls (v 69% of boys). ([GOV.UK](#) / [DfE](#), [Anna Freud](#), [UCL](#), [Ipsos](#))

→ **For your school:** *A useful evidence point for inclusion and pastoral teams making the case for targeted belonging work with SEN pupils and girls.*

SHEFFIELD: SAFETY ALERT NEAR CHELSEA PARK/NETHER EDGE

- **High Storrs School wrote to parents after reports of a man approaching pupils.** The Bents Green secondary told families on Wednesday that South Yorkshire Police had received reports of an adult male approaching and trying to engage young people in conversation near Chelsea Park on recent evenings. The school asked families to go through personal safety advice for journeys to and from school. ([The Star](#))

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

54% v 66%

Year 8 pupils receiving SEN support who said they felt a sense of belonging at school, against their peers without SEN support.

DfE / Anna Freud, UCL, Ipsos - 'Growing Up in the 2020s', published 1 Oct 2026

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.